



SAFE

Keeping perishable foods like cooked chicken and potato salad cold (below 40°F) and out of the danger zone (40-140°F) slows harmful bacteria growth. Serving within two hours ensures safety. The cooler being in the shade with ice packs maintained the needed cold temperature.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics



NOT SAFE

Cooked meat left at room temperature for more than two hours is unsafe because harmful bacteria grow quickly in the 'danger zone' between 40°F and 140°F. Eating this hamburger could cause food poisoning, as bacteria like Salmonella multiply rapidly.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics



IT DEPENDS

Blanching then freezing vegetables slows bacterial growth, making freezing safe. But if vegetables thaw and warm above 40°F for too long, bacteria can grow and make them unsafe. If they still have ice crystals when power returns and were kept cold enough less than two days, refreezing can be safe.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables



SAFE

This approach is safe because peaches are a high-acid fruit that can be safely processed in a boiling water canner. Using sterilized jars, following the correct processing time, allowing proper headspace, cooling jars correctly, and storing in a cool, dark place prevents growth of harmful microorganisms and spoilage.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



NOT SAFE

This is not safe because many fruits need added acid (like lemon juice) to ensure safe acidity levels for boiling water canning. Processing too short, not adjusting for altitude, or overfilling jars can prevent destroying harmful bacteria or achieving a proper vacuum seal. This may cause spoilage or botulism risk. Always follow tested recipes, add acid if called for, process full time, and maintain headspace.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



IT DEPENDS

Safety depends on the acidity of the fruit and recommended process. Asian pears are borderline low-acid and may require adding lemon juice or other acid to safely process in a boiling water canner. If acid isn't added, pressure canning may be needed. Always follow research-based instructions for specific fruit types and recipes to ensure safety.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



SAFE

This salsa is safe because Jamie followed a tested recipe that ensures enough acidity by adding lemon juice to tomatoes. Using high-quality tomatoes and processing in a boiling water canner properly prevents harmful bacteria like botulism.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning



NOT SAFE

This salsa is unsafe because reducing vinegar lowers acidity, which increases risk for botulism. Adding fresh garlic and herbs before canning also affects acidity and safety. Both changes can allow harmful bacteria to grow during boiling water canning.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning



IT DEPENDS

Adding extra corn and beans before canning changes the acid balance and may lower the acidity, increasing botulism risk. These salsas must be canned according to tested recipes that account for such ingredients. If no tested recipe exists, it's safer to freeze instead.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning



SAFE

Low-acid foods like green beans must be pressure canned to kill bacteria like *Clostridium botulinum*. Using a tested recipe with the correct pressure, time, and equipment ensures safety. Checking your canner's dial gauge each year ensures it works properly.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game



NOT SAFE

Cooked potatoes are low-acid foods and need pressure canning to reach temperatures high enough to kill botulism spores. Using only boiling water canning is not safe and can allow harmful bacteria to grow, even if the jar looks fine.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game



IT DEPENDS

Low acid foods need precise processing times to destroy dangerous bacteria.

Shortening the time may result in unsafe food. Whether it's safe depends on how much time was cut, the type of food, and the canner's temperature. It's safer to follow tested times exactly.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game



SAFE

Using a tested recipe with vinegar that has 5% acidity ensures the pickles are acidic enough to prevent harmful bacteria. Refrigeration slows down spoilage. Consuming within 2 weeks means the pickles remain fresh and safe.

Source: NCHFP Pickled eggs



NOT SAFE

Homemade vinegar with unknown acidity may not be acidic enough to prevent harmful bacteria like *Clostridium botulinum*. Skipping boiling water processing risks unsafe contamination. Storing at room temperature increases the danger of bacteria growth.

Source: NCHFP Pickled eggs



IT DEPENDS

Fermentation safety depends on using the proper amount of salt to encourage good bacteria and keep bad bacteria out. Clean equipment and fresh vegetables are also needed. If these conditions aren't met, harmful bacteria might grow.

Source: UC David Safely fermented fruit and vegetable



SAFE

Freezer jams that use tested low-sugar pectin recipes and are kept frozen are safe. The freezing stops bacterial growth, and the tested recipe ensures the right acidity and pectin for safety and texture. Just follow the instructions on the pectin package and store the jam in the freezer until use.

Source: SP 50-763 Uncooked freezer jams



NOT SAFE

Skipping the boiling water bath means the jam isn't processed to kill bacteria and molds that can grow in home-canned food. Even acid jams need processing to be safe on the shelf. Without processing, your jam could spoil or cause food poisoning like botulism.

Source: SP 50-764 Making jam jellies fruit spreads



IT DEPENDS

Elderberry jelly safety depends on the variety of elderberry used because some have too low acidity for safe home canning with regular recipes. The native blue elderberry is safe with normal boiling water canning, but European and American elderberries need special high sugar recipes or freezing to be safe. Always identify your berry variety and follow the correct recipe.

Source: SP 50-536 Wild berries and fruits



SAFE

Quick cooling stops bacteria from growing before freezing. Freezing at 0°F keeps the soup safe for months by halting bacteria growth. Leaving headspace lets the soup expand when frozen, preventing container breakage. Always use freezer-safe containers.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home



NOT SAFE

Freezing raw meat without packaging can allow freezer burns and contamination. Thawing meat on the counter lets harmful bacteria grow rapidly at room temperature. Meat must be thawed safely in the fridge or cold water, never at room temperature.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home



IT DEPENDS

Leftover cooked rice must be cooled quickly and frozen soon to stay safe because it can grow bacteria that cause food poisoning. Thawing frozen veggies in the fridge is safe, as is cooking them straight from frozen. The safety depends on how long the rice stayed in the danger zone before freezing and vegetable acidity.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables



SAFE

Jerky is only safe if the meat reaches 160°F to destroy harmful bacteria such as Salmonella and E. coli. Using a dehydrator that keeps a steady temperature of 145°F-155°F and verifying the final internal temperature ensures safety. This method prevents foodborne illness and allows jerky to be shelf-stable for weeks.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely



NOT SAFE

Smoking fish without controlling temperature or time can allow dangerous bacteria or parasites to survive. Unlike proper cooking, cold or uncontrolled smoking does not reliably kill pathogens, risking foodborne illness such as from *Clostridium botulinum* or parasites like *Trichinella*.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home



IT DEPENDS

Drying acidic fruits like tomatoes is usually safer because harmful bacteria grow less in acid. However, safety depends on how long you dry them, the drying temperature, and finishing steps. Tomatoes need to be dried until moisture is low enough to prevent spoilage, and if not dried properly, can still grow mold or bacteria.

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables